Plan 1 · Classic Shimla + Manali

The standard circuit done well: Shimla, Kufri, Narkanda–Hatu Peak, Manali, Solang, Atal Tunnel–Sissu, Naggar, Jana, Sethan, Kasol–Manikaran. 24 Dec 2026 – 3 Jan 2027 · Hyderabad round trip by train

At a glance

Route	Hyderabad → (train) → Delhi → (HRTC Volvo) → Shimla 3N → (bus) → Manali 4N → Kasol/Manikaran day → (Volvo from Bhuntar) → Delhi → (train) → Hyderabad
Nights	2 on train out · 3 Shimla · 4 Manali · 1 Volvo · 1 train back
Snow chances	High at Hatu Peak, Solang, Atal Tunnel–Sissu and Sethan. Medium at Kufri and Narkanda. Low in Shimla town (some years)
Crowd level	High at Mall Road, Kufri, Solang and Atal Tunnel on 25 Dec and 31 Dec–1 Jan. Low at Hatu, Tani Jubbar, Jana, Sethan, Naggar
Difficulty	Easy. No trekking needed (Jogini falls and Hatu walk are optional)
Budget (per person, group of 4)	≈ ₹24.6k shoestring (SL + hostels) · ≈ ₹30.8k recommended (3A + budget hotels)
Temperatures	Shimla −2 to 10 °C · Manali −5 to 7 °C · Sissu/Hatu −10 to −2 °C

Why this works with your dates

24 Dec morning train → Delhi on 25 Dec morning → Shimla the same evening (Christmas on the Ridge). You leave the hills on 1 Jan and Delhi on 2 Jan, so 3 Jan is a buffer.

Offbeat add-ons sit next to the main sights: Hatu Peak + Tani Jubbar (beyond Kufri), Jana waterfall + Sethan (beyond Naggar), Jogini falls (beyond Vashisht), Chalal/Tosh (beyond Kasol).

Getting there and back

Hyderabad → Delhi: trains that work for 24 Dec (early morning first)

Train	Boards in Hyderabad	Reaches	Runs	Classes · approx fare / person	Use on 24 Dec?
12723 Telangana SF Exp	Hyderabad Deccan (Nampally) **06:00** · Secunderabad 06:20/06:25	New Delhi ~07:40–08:00 next day (~25.5 h)	Daily	SL ≈ ₹800 · 3A ≈ ₹2,100 · 2A ≈ ₹3,000	**Yes, best early-morning train**
22691 Bengaluru–Nizamuddin Rajdhani	Secunderabad **07:00 arr / 07:10 dep** (10-min halt)	H. Nizamuddin ~05:30 next day (~22 h)	Daily	3A ≈ ₹3,300–4,100 · 2A ≈ ₹4,500–5,500 (flexi fare, meals incl.)	Yes. Fastest morning option
12285 Secunderabad–Nizamuddin Duronto	Secunderabad **12:50**	H. Nizamuddin ~10:40 next day (~22 h)	**Sun & Thu**	AC only · 3A ≈ ₹3,000–3,700 (meals incl.)	**Yes, 24 Dec is a Thursday**
12721 Dakshin SF Exp	Hyderabad Deccan 23:00	H. Nizamuddin ~03:45 on day 3 (~29 h)	Daily	SL ≈ ₹780 · 3A ≈ ₹2,100	Only as a 23-Dec-night fallback (slow)

12723 major halts, in order (check availability to each): Hyderabad Deccan → Secunderabad → Kazipet → Ramagundam → Mancherial → Sirpur Kagaznagar → Balharshah → Chandrapur → Sevagram → Nagpur → Itarsi → Bhopal → Jhansi → Gwalior → Agra Cantt → New Delhi (about 18 halts in total, ~1,680 km). Confirmed times: HYB 06:00, SC 06:20/06:25, Kazipet 08:03/08:05, Ramagundam 09:28/09:30. Read the other times off NTES or IRCTC on the day.

Waitlisted? Check every halt this way

Step 1. Direct pairs. On IRCTC (or ConfirmTkt / ixigo, same data), search 24 Dec for HYB→NDLS, SC→NDLS, SC→NZM, HYB→NZM in 3A and SL. Note the status for each train: AVAILABLE / RAC / WL number.

Step 2. Every halt (as you asked). If HYB/SC→Delhi shows WL, search the same train from **HYB** to each later halt: Agra Cantt, Gwalior, Jhansi, Bhopal, Itarsi, Nagpur. Seats are split into quotas by distance, so a shorter ticket (e.g. HYB→Agra) can be AVAILABLE while HYB→Delhi is WL. If Agra/Gwalior is available, book it, ride to Agra (about 4 h before Delhi), then take any Agra→Delhi train, Gatimaan/Vande Bharat or bus (2–3.5 h, ₹300–800).

Step 3. Book from the train's origin. For trains that start outside Hyderabad (22691 Rajdhani from Bengaluru, 22705 Humsafar from Tirupati), search **origin→Delhi** (SBC→NZM, TPTY→NZM/Jammu) and set **Boarding Point = Secunderabad**. You pay the full-route fare, but the origin's general quota is often open when the Secunderabad quota is full.

Step 4. Board further up the line. Check the same trains from Kazipet / Ramagundam (table above). You can book HYB→Delhi and board at SC, but you cannot board before the boarding station on your ticket.

Step 5. Split journey. HYB→Nagpur (many trains, short) + Nagpur→Delhi (30+ trains, incl. Rajdhanis from the south). Leave at least 2–3 h for the change.

Step 6. Tatkal on 23 Dec. AC Tatkal opens 10:00 AM, sleeper 11:00 AM. You need an Aadhaar-authenticated IRCTC account (OTP). Log in at 9:55 with saved passenger lists and UPI ready. Premium Tatkal costs more but is easier to get.

Delhi → Hyderabad: trains that get you home by 3 Jan

Train	Leaves	Reaches Hyderabad	Runs	Approx fare (3A)	Fits 'home by 3 Jan'?
12724 Telangana SF Exp	New Delhi **16:00**	Hyderabad Deccan ~17:10 next day	Daily	≈ ₹2,100 (SL ≈ ₹800)	**Leave 2 Jan → home 3 Jan evening**
22692 Nizamuddin–Bengaluru Rajdhani	H. Nizamuddin late evening (≈20:30–21:00, verify)	Secunderabad 17:10 arr / 17:25 dep next day	Daily	≈ ₹3,300–4,100	**Leave 2 Jan → home 3 Jan 17:10**
12286 Nizamuddin–Secunderabad Duronto	H. Nizamuddin 15:55	Secunderabad ~14:35 next day	Mon & Fri	≈ ₹3,000–3,700	Leave 1 Jan (Fri) → home 2 Jan
12722 Dakshin SF Exp	H. Nizamuddin 22:50	Hyderabad Deccan ~03:50 on day 3	Daily	≈ ₹2,100	Leave 1 Jan night → home 3 Jan 04:00

Delhi ↔ Shimla ↔ Manali connections

Leg	Best option	Time	Approx cost / person	Book on
Delhi → Shimla	HRTC Himsuta AC Volvo from ISBT Kashmere Gate (departures around 06:45, 08:00, 09:25, 11:55, 21:00). From New Delhi station take the Metro Yellow Line to Kashmere Gate (2 stops, ~₹30)	8–9.5 h	₹980–1,100	online.hrtchp.com, redBus, AbhiBus
Alt: Delhi → Kalka → Shimla (toy train)	14095 Himalayan Queen (Delhi Sarai Rohilla 05:35 → Kalka 11:10) + 52455 toy train (Kalka 12:10 → Shimla ~17:20). Only works if you're in Delhi the night before	~12 h	Train ₹150–500 + toy train ₹400–550	IRCTC
Shimla → Manali	HRTC from ISBT Tutikandi, Shimla, via Mandi–Kullu (morning departures 06:00–09:00)	8–10 h	₹550–650 (ordinary/deluxe) · Volvo ~₹900 if running · private cab ₹6,500–8,000 per car	HRTC counter / online
Manali / Bhuntar → Delhi	HRTC or private Volvo, evening departures 16:00–19:00, reaches Kashmere Gate / Majnu ka Tilla 06:00–08:00	12–14 h	₹1,600–2,000 (HRTC ~₹1,670; private NYE week ₹1,800–3,000)	HRTC / redBus. Choose boarding point Bhuntar if coming from Kasol

Flights from Hyderabad (to save 1–2 days)

Route (non-stop)	Airlines	Flight time	Typical Dec–Jan one-way fare*	Useful for
Hyderabad ↔ Delhi	IndiGo, Air India, Akasa, SpiceJet (many daily)	~2 h 10 m	₹6,000–9,000 (24 Dec / 2 Jan can touch ₹10–12k)	Plans 1, 2, 3, 5
Hyderabad → Chandigarh	IndiGo (≈2 daily)	~2 h 30 m	₹7,000–9,500	Plans 1 & 2 (Shimla is 3–4 h from IXC)

*Snapshot ranges from MakeMyTrip, Goibibo, Skyscanner, HappyFares and ixigo pages seen in Nov 2026, not live quotes. IndiGo cabin bag: 7 kg; check-in 15 kg on most fares. Winter jackets count, so wear the heaviest layers on the plane. Book within the next 1–2 weeks: Christmas/New Year fares on these routes usually climb steadily.

Fast alternative (+1 day in the hills, +₹8–12k)

Fly Hyderabad → Chandigarh on 24 Dec morning (IndiGo, ~2.5 h), then HRTC Volvo / taxi Chandigarh → Shimla (3–4 h, Volvo ₹500–650, taxi ₹3,000–3,500). You sleep in Shimla on 24 Dec and gain a day for Chail (offbeat palace town + world's highest cricket ground) or Tattapani hot springs. Fly Delhi → Hyderabad on 2 Jan evening if you want to skip the 25 h train ride back.

Day-by-day itinerary

Day 1 · Thu 24 Dec · Hyderabad → on the train

• **06:00** 12723 Telangana Express from Hyderabad Deccan (or 06:25 Secunderabad). Alternative: **07:10 22691 Rajdhani** from Secunderabad (reaches Nizamuddin 05:30, so you can take the 06:45/08:00 Volvo and reach Shimla by afternoon).

• Carry dinner and next-day breakfast; e-catering (IRCTC eCatering / RailRestro) delivers at Nagpur, Bhopal and Jhansi.

• Keep winter layers in the top bag. North India mornings are 5–8 °C and foggy, and fog can delay trains 1–4 h.

Stay: Train (3A/SL) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹300 food

Day 2 · Fri 25 Dec · Delhi → Shimla (Christmas on the Ridge)

• ~07:40 New Delhi → Metro Yellow Line to Kashmere Gate ISBT → **09:25 HRTC Volvo** (fallback 11:55) → Shimla ~18:30 (Old Bus Stand / Tutikandi ISBT, then a local bus or taxi ₹300–400 to Mall Road). **Book the bus seat in advance for 25 Dec.**

• Evening: Christ Church lit up for Christmas, the Ridge, Scandal Point, Mall Road. The Shimla Winter Carnival usually runs on the Ridge from around 25 Dec to 1 Jan.

Stay: Budget hotel near Mall / Lakkar Bazaar (₹1,800–2,800 per room) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,000 bus + ₹600 food

Day 3 · Sat 26 Dec · Shimla sightseeing + offbeat walks

• Jakhoo Temple (ropeway or a steep 30-min walk; watch out for monkeys, keep specs and phones inside), Christ Church, Gaiety Theatre, Lakkar Bazaar woodcraft.

• **Shimla Ice Skating Rink** (one of Asia's oldest natural rinks) usually opens late Dec–Jan if nights are cold enough. Morning and evening sessions, skates on hire.

• Afternoon: Indian Institute of Advanced Study (Viceregal Lodge, guided tour) → walk the quiet Summer Hill / Annandale side.

• Optional offbeat: Tara Devi temple (sunset view) or the Glen forest walk.

Stay: Same hotel | **Day spend (per person):** ₹500 entries + ₹700 food + ₹200 local

Day 4 · Sun 27 Dec · Kufri → Fagu → Narkanda → Hatu Peak → Tani Jubbar (snow day)

• Hire a cab for the day (₹3,500–4,500 per car). Leave by 08:00 to beat Kufri traffic.

• **Kufri** (main sight): Mahasu Peak pony ride (₹500–800, bargain), snow-point stalls. It's crowded, so keep it short.

• **Narkanda (2,708 m)**: HPTDC ski slopes if snow has settled. **Hatu Peak (3,400 m)**: wooden Hatu Mata temple, 360° Himalayan view. If the last 7 km is snow-bound, walk it (2–2.5 h up) or turn back.

• **Tani Jubbar lake** (offbeat, 8 km from Narkanda): quiet lake ringed by deodars. Back in Shimla by 19:00.

• Rent a snow suit + gumboots at Kufri/Narkanda stalls only if there's fresh snow (₹300–500).

Stay: Same hotel | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,000 cab share + ₹500 activities + ₹700 food

Day 5 · Mon 28 Dec · Shimla → Manali by HRTC

• Early HRTC from Tutikandi ISBT (06:00–08:00) via Bilaspur → Sundernagar lake → Mandi → Pandoh Dam → Aut Tunnel → Kullu → Manali (~17:00).

• Sit on the right side after Mandi for the Beas gorge. A shared private cab is faster (7–8 h) at ₹6,500–8,000 per car.

• Evening: Mall Road, Manu Market momos, Tibetan Monastery.

Stay: Old Manali / Vashisht guesthouse (₹2,000–3,500/room NYE week) or hostel dorm ₹700–1,500 | **Day spend (per person):** ₹600 bus + ₹700 food

Day 6 · Tue 29 Dec · Solang Valley → Atal Tunnel → Sissu (Lahaul)

• Leave by **07:00**. Holiday queues to the tunnel build up from 09:00. Local taxi union rate for Solang + Atal Tunnel + Sissu: ≈ ₹3,500–4,500 per car (more for Innova/after fresh snow). Self-drive two-wheelers aren't safe on icy stretches.

• Rent suit + gumboots at Palchan/Solang (₹300–500). Solang: ropeway (₹500–800), skiing lesson (₹1,000–1,500/hr), snow scooter / ATV (₹1,000–2,000, bargain hard). Paragliding depends on weather.

• **Atal Tunnel (9.02 km) → Sissu**: frozen waterfall, Chandra river, Lahaul snowscape. No permit needed for the tunnel. Police may stop vehicles at Solang/Dhundi after heavy snow, and then Solang is the snow point.

Stay: Same | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,125 cab share + ₹1,500 activities/rent + ₹700 food

Day 7 · Wed 30 Dec · Manali local by scooty + Jogini falls (offbeat)

• Rent a scooty (₹500–800/day + ₹1,000–2,000 deposit; Old Manali / Mall Road shops). Ride only on cleared roads.

• Hadimba Devi temple & Dhungri forest → Ghatotkacha shrine → Manu Temple → Old Manali cafés.

• Vashisht: hot-spring baths & temple → **Jogini waterfall** trek (~2.5 km each way from Vashisht, 2–3 h return).

• Evening: Club House, Mall Road shopping (Kullu shawls, caps).

Stay: Same | **Day spend (per person):** ₹350 scooty share + ₹200 fuel + ₹800 food

Day 8 · Thu 31 Dec · Naggar → Jana waterfall → Sethan · New Year's Eve

• Cab circuit (₹2,500–3,000 per car): **Naggar Castle** (1460s wood-and-stone castle, small entry fee) + **Roerich Art Gallery**.

• **Jana waterfall** (offbeat): lunch of makki-di-roti, sarson-da-saag and siddu at the village dhabas.

• **Sethan** (12 km above Prini): quiet snow village with igloo cafés and a short snow walk on the Hampta trail. Far fewer people than Solang.

• NYE in Old Manali (cafés with live music, dinner ₹600–1,200) or a bonfire at your guesthouse. Book dinner tables early.

Stay: Same | **Day spend (per person):** ₹700 cab share + ₹1,200 NYE dinner

Day 9 · Fri 1 Jan · Manali → Kasol, Manikaran → overnight Volvo to Delhi

• Check out by 08:00. 1 Jan traffic down to Kullu is heavy. Cab / local bus to Bhuntar → **Kasol** (Parvati valley, 32 km).

• **Manikaran Sahib**: hot springs, free langar. **Chalal** village walk (30 min along the Parvati). Tosh adds ~3 h, so only if time allows.

• Board the evening **Volvo to Delhi from Bhuntar** (book Manali→Delhi with boarding point Bhuntar/Kullu, 18:00–19:30).

Stay: Overnight Volvo | **Day spend (per person):** ₹875 cab share + ₹1,800 Volvo + ₹600 food

Day 10 · Sat 2 Jan · Delhi → train home

• Reach Majnu ka Tilla / Kashmere Gate ~06:00–08:00. Freshen up (station retiring room, or a Paharganj day room ₹800–1,200 shared).

• Optional: Connaught Place, India Gate, or Humayun's Tomb if leaving from Nizamuddin.

• **16:00 12724 Telangana Express** from New Delhi (backup: 22692 Rajdhani from Nizamuddin late evening).

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹300 room share + ₹600 food

Day 11 · Sun 3 Jan · Home

• Reach Hyderabad Deccan ~17:10 (Rajdhani: Secunderabad 17:10).

Places covered

Place	Type	Why go	Crowd (late Dec)
Shimla Ridge, Mall, Christ Church, Jakhoo	Main	Colonial heart of Shimla; Christmas lights	Very high
Kufri	Main	Snow point, pony rides	Very high
Narkanda + Hatu Peak	Offbeat	Best snow near Shimla, 3,400 m temple top	Low–medium
Tani Jubbar lake	Offbeat	Quiet lake in a deodar bowl	Low
Ice skating rink, Shimla	Seasonal	Natural ice; only on cold nights	Medium
Solang, Atal Tunnel, Sissu	Main	Assured snow and Lahaul views	Very high
Hadimba, Old Manali, Vashisht	Main	Temples, cafés, hot springs	High
Jogini falls	Offbeat	Short forest trek to a frozen-ish fall	Low
Naggar Castle, Roerich gallery	Semi-offbeat	Old capital of Kullu, art	Low
Jana waterfall, Sethan	Offbeat	Village food; igloo snow village	Low
Kasol, Manikaran, Chalal (Tosh optional)	Main + offbeat	Parvati valley, hot springs, langar	Medium

Bike / scooty rentals on this route

Town	Rates (per day)	Where / how	Notes
Manali	Scooty ₹500–800 · RE Classic 350 ₹1,200–1,500 · Himalayan ₹1,500–2,500	Shops on Mall Road, Old Manali, Vashisht; online: Bike Wale Bhaiya, Riderly, local WhatsApp rentals	Deposit ₹1,000–2,000 + original DL. No riding beyond Solang on snow/ice. Most rentals ban taking bikes over Atal Tunnel in winter
Shimla	Scooty ₹500–800 · 150–200 cc ₹900–1,500	Near Shimla ISBT / Lakkar Bazaar	Mall Road is pedestrian. Use the bike for Kufri/Chail only on clear days
Kasol	Scooty ₹600–900 · RE ₹1,200–1,600	Kasol main market	Handy for Manikaran–Barshaini (Tosh) if roads are dry

Winter gear: what to buy, what to rent, and where

Budget for gear: if you own nothing warm, expect ₹4,000–6,500 one-time purchase (thermals, fleece, gloves, cap, socks, sunglasses) + ₹800–1,500 in rentals on the trip (jacket, suit, boots, spikes). The per-plan budgets include only the **rental** part; the purchases you keep are listed separately.

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
Thermal inner set (top + bottom) ×2	Must	₹800–1,200 per set (local ₹400–600)	Not rented (hygiene)	Buy. Merino/poly, not cotton
Fleece / sweater (mid layer)	Must	₹600–1,200	—	Buy
Padded / down jacket (rated −5 to −10 °C)	Must	₹2,500–5,000	Indiahikes rentals ₹55–80/day (ships to you); trek operators ₹100/day; Manali / Gulmarg shops ₹150–300/day	Rent if you'll never use it again. 10 days ≈ ₹600–1,000
One-piece snow suit	At snow points	—	Solang/Palchan, Kufri, Gulmarg, Tsomgo ₹250–500/day (often with gumboots)	Rent on the spot only on snow days
Gumboots / snow boots	At snow points	—	₹100–200/day (Lachung ~₹100; bundled with suit at Solang ₹400–500)	Rent on the spot

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
Waterproof trekking shoes	Must (Plans 2, 4, 5)	₹2,000–3,500 (Decathlon MH100/MH500)	Trek operators ₹100–150/day	Buy if you'll trek again
Waterproof gloves + woollen inners	Must	₹300–900 + ₹150	—	Buy
Woollen cap / balaclava / neck gaiter	Must	₹200–400 each	—	Buy
Woollen socks (4 pairs)	Must	₹400–600	—	Buy
UV400 sunglasses	Must on snow	₹300–800	—	Snow glare causes snow-blindness
Microspikes + gaiters	Chopta, Hatu, Jalori, Gulmarg walks	₹1,200–1,800	Chopta/Sari/Sankri ₹150–250/day; gaiters ₹100/day	Rent

Rental points on this route

Point	What you can rent	Rate
Kufri / Narkanda stalls	Snow suit, gumboots	₹300–500 per set/day
Palchan / Solang (before Atal Tunnel)	One-piece suit + gumboots + gloves, ski kit	₹300–500 suit+boots; ski kit + lesson ₹1,000–1,500
Manali Mall Road / Old Manali	Down jackets, boots (also cheap to buy at the Tibetan market)	₹150–300/day
Indiahikes rentals (online, ships to you)	Padded jacket (−10 °C), trek shoes, poles	₹55–100/day

Budget (per person, 4 people sharing rooms and cabs)

Item (per person)	Shoestring	Recommended	Notes
Train Hyderabad → Delhi	₹800	₹2,100	SL vs 3A, Telangana Exp
Train Delhi → Hyderabad	₹800	₹2,100	SL vs 3A
Delhi → Shimla HRTC Volvo	₹1,000	₹1,000	Book early for 25 Dec
Shimla → Manali HRTC	₹600	₹600	Deluxe/ordinary
Bhuntar/Manali → Delhi Volvo	₹1,600	₹1,800	NYE-week fares
Metro, autos, local buses	₹400	₹500	
Sightseeing cabs (Narkanda day, Solang–Sissu, Naggar–Sethan, Kasol)	₹3,600	₹3,600	₹14.5k of cabs ÷ 4
Scooty day (2 per scooty) + fuel	₹450	₹550	
Stays: 3N Shimla + 4N Manali	₹6,000	₹8,000	Hostel dorms vs budget hotel rooms (2/room)
Food, 10 days (incl. train food)	₹6,000	₹6,500	₹600–650/day
Activities & entry tickets	₹1,500	₹2,000	Solang ropeway/skiing, Naggar, Jakhoo, skating
Winter gear rentals	₹800	₹1,000	Suit, boots, jacket
Buffer (tips, delays, NYE)	₹1,000	₹1,000	
TOTAL per person	**₹24,550**	**₹30,750**	**Within ₹25–31k. Each extra person in the car saves ~₹700. Flying one way adds ₹5–8k.**

Bookings to do now (in this order)

- **Today:** return train for 2 Jan (12724 / 22692). The booking window opened on 3 Nov. Then the onward train for 24 Dec (12723 / 22691 / 12285), using the halt-by-halt method above if it shows WL.
- HRTC Volvo Delhi → Shimla for 25 Dec, and the Manali → Delhi Volvo for 1 Jan (HRTC opens about 30 days ahead; private operators earlier).
- Manali stay for 28 Dec – 1 Jan (NYE week sells out). Pick free cancellation.
- Shimla stay 25–28 Dec. Don't pre-book Shimla→Manali buses. Book the morning ticket at Tutikandi the evening before.

Plan B if snow or traffic hits

- Atal Tunnel closed after snowfall: go to Solang/Dhundi, or swap with Day 8 (Sethan usually has snow and less crowd).
- Hatu road snow-bound: walk partway, or switch to Chail + Kufri. Narkanda town itself usually stays reachable.
- Train reaches Delhi late (fog): take the 11:55 Volvo, or the overnight 21:00 Volvo and sleep on the bus. Shift Shimla sightseeing to Day 3.
- 1 Jan jams near Manali: skip Kasol and board the Volvo from Manali directly (16:00–17:00).

Carry list

- Original photo ID (Aadhaar/DL) + 2 photocopies + **4 passport photos** (Sikkim permits, J&K checks).
- Power bank (cold drains batteries 2× faster), offline Google Maps, cash ₹5–8k (ATMs fail in snow areas).
- Basic meds: Diamox (only after a doctor's advice) for Nathula / Chandrashila / Zuluk, paracetamol, ORS, cold & cough tabs, band-aids, Vaseline.
- Small daypack, reusable bottle, thermos (hot water in −5 °C mornings), quick-dry towel, plastic bags for wet gear.
- Prepaid SIMs from outside J&K do not work in Kashmir. Carry at least one **postpaid** connection (Plan 3).

Safety & buffers

- Snow and roads change by the hour. Check HP/J&K/Sikkim/Uttarakhand police traffic updates and ask your homestay every evening. National emergency: **112**. HP disaster helpline: **1077**.
- Do not ride rented two-wheelers on fresh snow or black ice (Solang–Atal Tunnel, Narkanda, Gulmarg road, Chopta). Taxis with snow chains are safer after snowfall.
- Book stays for 24 Dec–1 Jan **in advance** (NYE rates in Manali/Shimla/Gulmarg/Darjeeling go 2–3× normal). Prefer free-cancellation rates.
- Keep 3 Jan as a pure buffer: plan to start the last long leg (hills → Delhi/airport) by 1 Jan, because snow and NYE traffic delay buses 3–8 h.

Sources checked

Reddit could not be searched from this environment (blocked), so traveller reports came from Team-BHP, Tripoto, travel blogs and local news. Live seat availability and live fares could not be fetched (IRCTC needs login and captcha). Use the checklists above to verify.

— Train timings/days: Wikipedia (Telangana Exp, Duronto, Rajdhani pages), ConfirmTkt, totaltraininfo, ixigo, RailMitra, Trainman, gettraininfo (Nov 2026 search)
— IRCTC 60-day advance reservation rule (effective 1 Nov 2024): Business Today, India TV, Upstox; Aadhaar-verified booking updates: india.com, Patrika
— HRTC Volvo fares/timings: mytnstc.com HRTC table, EaseMyTrip, abhibus, trekgo Delhi–Shimla guide, himachal.exploreindia.in
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— Atal Tunnel/Sissu winter access & NYE traffic: The Tribune (Himachal), discoverkullumanali.in highway status 2026
— Manali rentals & snow gear: vargiskhan.com, travelcoffee.in, discoverwithdheeraj.com, Tripoto traveller notes, Thrillophilia
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